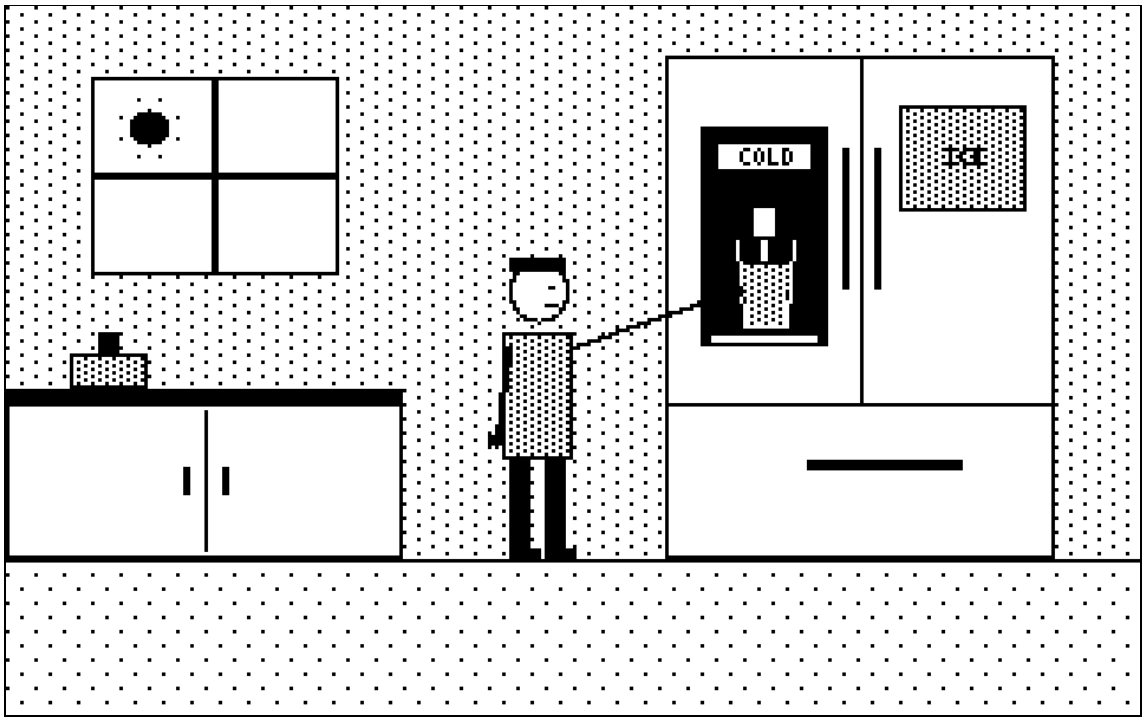
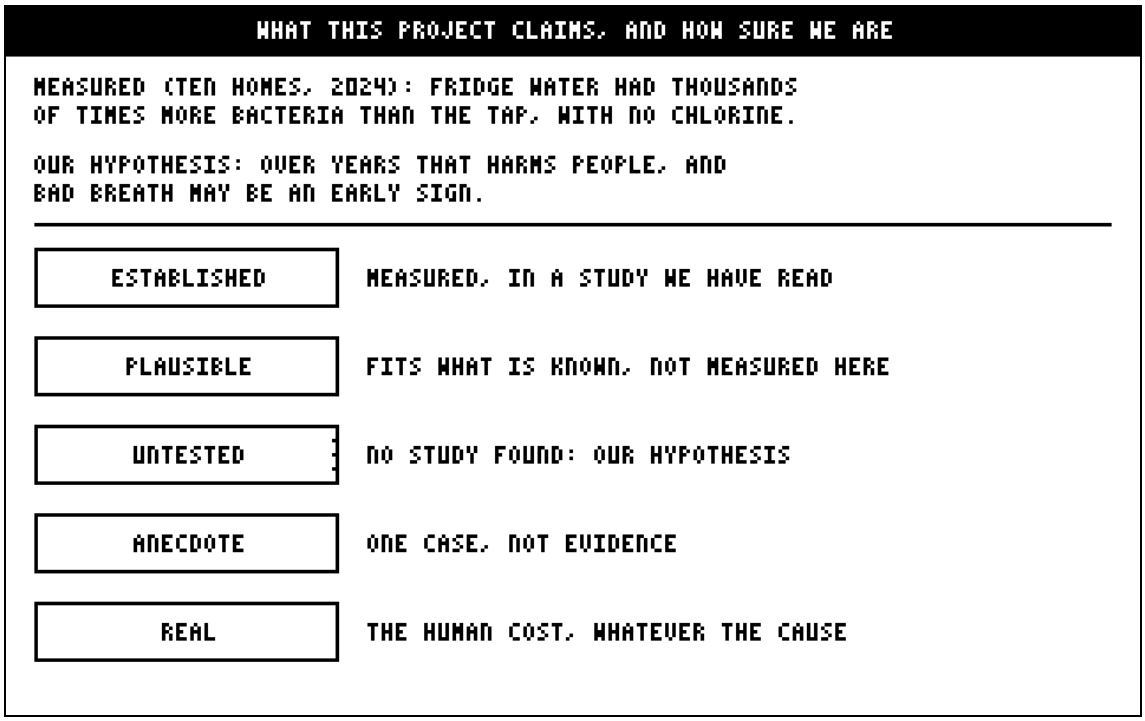
The Hygiene Trap

Scene 1 of 28: The pour

Kitchen



Frame 1. When the narrator says: “Picture someone who does this every day, for years. They…”

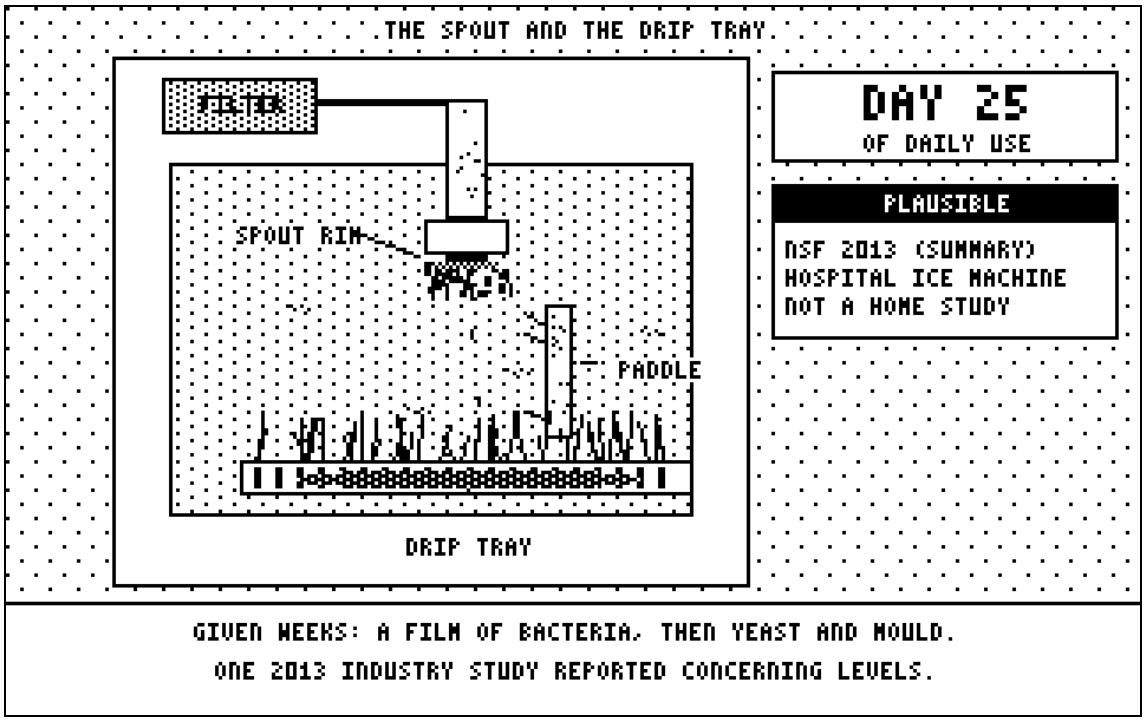


Frame 2. Made for print: what the project claims, how sure we are, and what each label means.

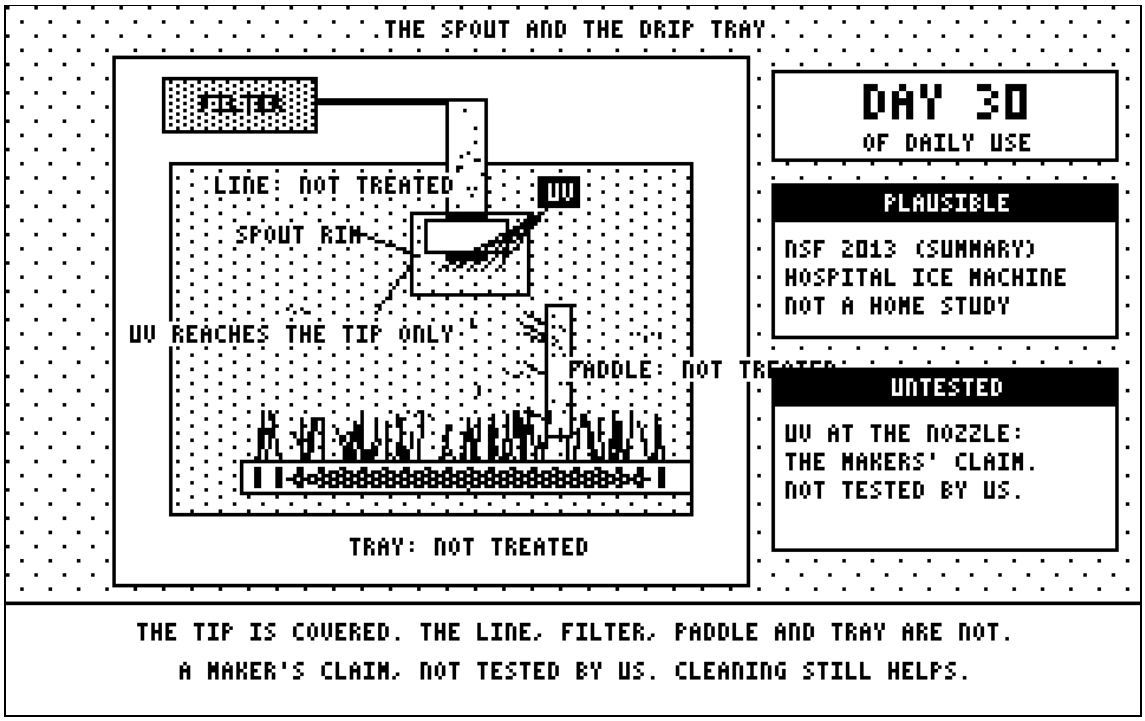
What the narrator says

1. Every morning, millions of people press a glass against a plastic paddle and drink cold water from the fridge.
2. Picture someone who does this every day, for years. They believe it's a healthy choice. The water is treated, and the fridge cost thousands.
3. But between the pipe in the wall and the glass in their hand, there's a filter and a stretch of plastic tubing that almost nobody thinks about.
4. Here's what has been measured. In ten homes, the water from a fridge dispenser carried thousands of times more bacteria than the tap feeding it.
5. Our hypothesis is what that does to a person over years, and that bad breath may be one of the first signs.
6. We'll show what's known, what it could cost, and how anyone could find out. Every claim gets a label as we go.

The spout



Frame 1. When the narrator says: “Given weeks, a film of bacteria can build up, then…”



Frame 2. When the narrator says: “That's how the makers describe it, and we haven't tested…”

What the narrator says

1. Now look at the spout itself. It's touched by hands, splashed by drips, and sits in open kitchen air, above a tray that stays damp.
2. Given weeks, a film of bacteria can build up, then yeast and mould. A 2013 industry study reported concerning levels at water and ice dispensers. We only have its summary.
3. A hospital study found related drug-resistant bacteria on an ice machine's spout and drain, and in patients. That's a hospital, not a home, but it shows a spout can hold them.
4. Some fridges now add an ultraviolet light at the nozzle. It can only treat what the light reaches, so the tip is covered, but the filter, lines, paddle and tray are not.
5. That's how the makers describe it, and we haven't tested it. Cleaning the spout and the tray is still the simplest fix.

References and notes

1. Swanson CS, He Q (2024). Linkage of in-refrigerator water dispensing systems to elevated exposure to microbial contamination at the microbiome scale. Am J Infect Control 52:857-859. PMID 38460731. doi:10.1016/j.ajic.2024.03.001
2. Kanwar A, Domitrovic TN, Koganti S, et al. (2017). A cold hard menace: A contaminated ice machine as a potential source for transmission of carbapenem-resistant Acinetobacter baumannii. Am J Infect Control 45:1273-1275. PMID 28625698. doi:10.1016/j.ajic.2017.05.007

Notes

- Swanson and He sampled ten homes in Knoxville, Tennessee. It is a short report; read in full.
- A 2013 industry (NSF) germ study reported concerning yeast and mould at water and ice dispensers; only a summary was seen, with no sample size or swab site. The hospital paper is about an ice machine, not a home. The UV light is the makers' claim, not tested by us.

Source: The Hygiene Trap, Scene 1 of 25: The pour. https://fridge-water.ownhealth.bio/fridge-water#s1 (whole site: https://fridge-water.ownhealth.bio/). Printed November 6, 2026.
Every claim carries a label: established, plausible, untested, anecdote or real. This is a hypothesis, not a diagnosis: for persistent bad breath or symptoms, see a dentist and a doctor.
Pictures and text: CC BY 4.0. Please credit the Fridge water project, https://github.com/aptitudetechnology/fridge-water.